

Recognize it

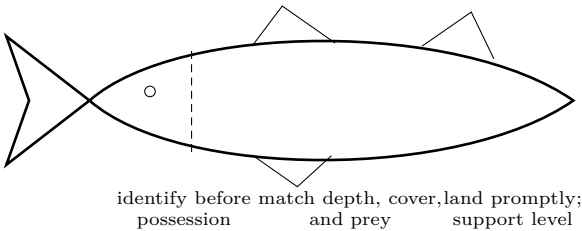
Bronze bass with vertical side bars; closed jaw does not extend beyond rear of eye.

Body	Elongate; dorsal sections connected with a shallow notch.
Mouth/fins	Large mouth smaller than largemouth's; tongue may have tooth patch.
Confusion	Largemouth is greener, has a strong horizontal band, and jaw extends past eye.

Lake role

Where it belongs
Rock, gravel, points, breaks, and crayfish-rich transitions.
Food and season
Crayfish and fish; shifts from warming shallows to deeper hard edges and fall prey routes.

A fish-shaped decision, not a lure list



Find it on these waters

Pine	Test gravel points and steep hard breaks; in clear water use long casts and natural depth control.
North	Test rocky narrows, points, and firm patches beside vegetation or current.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Presentations

1. **Tube or Ned rig.** Drag or short-hop across rock while maintaining bottom contact.
2. **Drop shot.** Hold a small bait above bottom when fish are marked but inactive.
3. **Stop rule.** Change casting angle before lure; if no hard bottom or prey evidence appears, relocate.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Land promptly, wet hands, support large fish level, and reduce air exposure in warm water.

Water-specific rule	May 2, 2026–Mar 7, 2027; 14-in minimum; bass daily bag 5 combined on both lakes.
Kitchen choice	If keeping one, choose a legal mid-size fish and release large adults; bass fall in predator meal advice.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

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